

Avadhana

अवधान — *undivided, focused attention*

A Commitment-First Platform for Civic & Social Problem-Solving — Product Specification

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1. Executive Summary

Avadhana is a social platform built on a single contrarian bet: that the dominant social media model — optimized for novelty, infinite scroll, and breadth of exposure — has made citizens spectators of the problems around them rather than contributors to solving them. Instagram, X, and Facebook are built to keep surfacing something new. Even community models like Reddit are structured around exploration across unlimited topics. The result is a citizen who sees ten problems in a feed and can act meaningfully on none of them — reduced, in practice, to a voter, a number, a passive audience.

Avadhana inverts this. A person selects at most three problems to actively work on. Once selected, they are locked into that problem for a minimum of ninety days — they cannot add a new problem, and cannot abandon the ones they've picked, until that window closes. Every problem is classified into a tier based on the scale of time or money required to solve it. Within a problem, people take on explicit roles — Thinker, Actor, or Financial Backer — and only people who have actually committed a slot to a given problem have a voice that counts in it. Everyone else can discover, read, and share the problem externally, but cannot dilute it with uncommitted opinion.

The street-vendor-gloves example used earlier is not the product — it is one possible problem someone might select on the platform, alongside things like organizing an RTI filing, contesting a local policy, or funding a legal case. The product is the focus mechanism itself, applicable to any civic, social, or community problem.

2. The Problem With the Status Quo

Today's major social platforms share a structural incentive: hold attention by continuously surfacing something new.

"You open your feed, you see ten different problems with society, and you can't do much. A citizen is minuted down to just a voter — a number in the roll. The amount of contribution you can make toward solving any one problem is minimal."

- Breadth over depth: platforms reward exploring many topics shallowly, not staying on one problem until it's resolved.
- No commitment mechanism: there is no structural cost to abandoning a cause after one post, so almost nothing gets followed through.
- Undifferentiated voice: a casual passerby's comment carries the same visible weight as a person

who has actually committed time, money, or action to a problem.

- Awareness without infrastructure: platforms are excellent at spreading awareness of a problem, and almost useless at organizing the roles (thinking, acting, funding) needed to actually resolve it.

3. Product Thesis & Naming

The name Avadhana comes from the Sanskrit word for focused, undivided attention — historically associated with a classical Indian intellectual tradition in which a practitioner holds several difficult mental threads at once, entirely through concentration. The platform borrows the word's core meaning — total, undivided attention — but applies it in the opposite direction: instead of holding many threads at once, a person on Avadhana deliberately narrows to very few, and stays with them.

3.1 How Avadhana differs from existing platforms

Instagram / X / Facebook	Novelty, constant new content, broad reach	No commitment mechanism; contribution is shallow (like/share) regardless of stake
Reddit	Exploration across unlimited communities	No cap on attention; a user's investment in any one topic is optional and undiscoverable
Change.org / petitions	Signature collection at scale	No ongoing roles or execution structure after signing; awareness without organized action
Avadhana	Sustained focus on very few problems	(by design) — breadth is deliberately restricted so depth becomes possible

4. Core Mechanics

4.1 The Focus Slot System

- Every user has exactly three "focus slots."
- Selecting a problem to work on consumes one slot.
- A user cannot select a fourth problem while all three slots are occupied — the system actively resists it, by design, rather than gently discouraging it.
- This is the platform's core point of friction, and the friction is the feature: it forces prioritization instead of accumulation.

4.2 The 90-Day Commitment Lock

- Once a slot is spent on a problem, it cannot be freed for a minimum of 90 days — regardless of whether the problem is progressing, stalled, or already resolved.
- At the 90-day mark, the user reaches a checkpoint and can choose to: mark the problem resolved, mark it abandoned (visible on their profile), or continue holding the slot.
- There is no early-exit option before day 90 — this is intentional, to prevent the platform from re-creating the same shallow, drop-in-drop-out behavior it's designed to avoid.

4.3 Problem Creation & Tier Classification

Anyone can propose a new problem. Each problem is assigned a tier reflecting the scale of time or money realistically needed to resolve it:

S	Systemic / national — requires sustained policy change, large funding, or long legal battles	Reforming a state-level regulation
A	Large regional — city- or district-wide coordinated effort	Citywide public sanitation enforcement
B	Community-scale — a neighborhood or a defined local group	Getting a local market's vendors certified for hygiene
C	Small and local — a handful of committed people can move it	Fixing a single unsafe street crossing
D	Individually actionable — quick, low-resource wins	Getting one shopkeeper to fix a broken sign

Tier is set when the problem is created and can be re-assessed by the community working on it as more information becomes available (see Section 8 on governance).

4.4 Roles Within a Problem

Thinker	Research, strategy, framing the problem, proposing approaches	Doesn't need to take physical/legal action or fund anything
Actor	On-ground execution — filing RTIs, organizing drives, meeting officials, pursuing legal cases	Doesn't need to personally fund the effort
Backer	Financial contribution to the problem's costs	Doesn't need to invest time in thinking or acting
Committed Member	Has spent one of their 3 slots here — full voice in discussion and decisions	N/A — this is the baseline for having a real say

4.5 Commitment-Gated Voice (anti-dilution mechanic)

"If I'm concerned about women's safety in my town, I should be focused on that only — I shouldn't be worried about who should be my cricket team's captain. That's not relevant to me."

- Anyone can search for a problem, view its feed, and read its progress — no login wall for discovery.
- Anyone can share a problem externally to Instagram, X, or elsewhere, to help recruit committed members.
- Only users who have spent one of their three slots on that specific problem can comment, vote, or otherwise influence its direction.
- A visitor who has not committed can still follow the problem passively, but their opinion does not carry decision-making weight — this is the mechanic that prevents any single problem's discussion from being diluted by uninvested drive-by opinions.

5. Feed & Discovery Model

- There is no algorithmic global feed optimized for novelty or engagement.
- A user's personal feed consists only of the (at most three) problems they've actively committed to — deep, not broad.
- Discovery of new problems happens through deliberate search (by topic, location, or tier), not passive scrolling.
- This is the platform's central design departure from Instagram/X/Reddit: discovery is opt-in and effortful, not ambient and effortless.

6. Key User Flows

6.1 Onboarding & first problem selection

- User signs up and is shown how the 3-slot system and 90-day lock work before selecting anything.
- User searches or browses tiered problems, or proposes their own.
- User selects a problem and a role (Thinker / Actor / Backer) — this spends one focus slot and starts the 90-day clock.

6.2 Proposing a new problem

- User writes a problem statement, scope, and location (if relevant).
- User proposes an initial tier (S–D) based on estimated time/money required.
- Problem becomes searchable immediately; other users can discover and commit to it.

6.3 Joining an existing problem

- User finds a problem via search or an external share link.
- If they have an open slot, they can commit to it and choose a role.
- If all three slots are full, the system blocks the commitment and explains why (see Section 4.1).

6.4 The 90-day checkpoint

- At day 90, the committed user is prompted: mark resolved, mark abandoned, or continue.
- Marking a problem abandoned is visible on the user's profile — there is a reputational cost to walking away, which discourages picking problems lightly.

6.5 External discovery / share-in visitor flow

- A non-member arrives via a shared link, reads the problem's progress, and can share it further.
- To actually comment or vote, they must commit a focus slot — read-only access remains open, participation does not.

7. Governance, Trust & Verification

- Tier disputes: committed members of a problem can propose a tier re-classification as more is learned about its true scope; requires a threshold of committed-member agreement.
- Resolution verification: marking a problem "resolved" should require more than a single user's

claim — likely a lightweight verification step among committed members, to keep the record honest.

- Preventing abuse: safeguards are needed against low-effort problem creation, coordinated brigading of a problem's role structure, and misuse of the platform for organizing real-world legal/RTI action without appropriate safeguards or disclaimers.
- Legal exposure: because Actors may file RTIs or pursue legal cases through problems organized on the platform, this needs dedicated legal review — the platform is facilitating real-world civic/legal action, not just discussion.

8. Success Metrics

% of committed problems reaching "resolved" by day 90	Whether focus + commitment actually produces outcomes
Ratio of committed members to passive observers per problem	Whether the anti-dilution mechanic is working as intended
Role distribution (Thinker / Actor / Backer) per problem	Whether problems are getting a functional mix of contributors, not just talk
Slot re-commitment rate after a 90-day checkpoint	Whether users stay engaged with civic problem-solving over time, or churn out

9. Open Questions & Risks

- Cold start: early problems need a critical mass of Thinkers, Actors, and Backers before the 3-slot restriction feels valuable rather than limiting.
- Hard lock frustration: a user stuck on a stagnant problem for 90 days with zero progress may disengage entirely rather than stay focused — may need an exceptional early-exit path with a real reputational cost, rather than none at all.
- Tier subjectivity: initial tier estimates will often be wrong; the re-classification process (Section 8) needs to be lightweight enough to actually get used.
- Legal liability: real-world actions (RTI filings, legal cases) organized through the platform raise jurisdiction-specific legal questions that need specialist review before launch.
- Growth tension: the entire mechanic depends on restricting behavior that every competing platform maximizes (novelty, breadth, low-friction posting) — go-to-market will need to sell the friction as the value, not hide it.

10. Next Steps

- Validate the core mechanic (3 slots + 90-day lock + tiered problems) with a small group of real users on 5–10 real local problems before building the full platform.
- Draft the tier rubric (S–D) in concrete, testable terms (estimated hours / estimated funding ranges) so classification is consistent.
- Get early legal input on the Actor role (RTI filings, legal case organizing) before this is enabled publicly.
- Design the core screens: problem search, the 3-slot profile view, a single problem's role-based discussion, and the 90-day checkpoint moment (see companion design).